



SWMS12

Safe Work Method Statement

Work on or near energised electrical installations or services

Document number	EC-SWMS12	Revision	1.0
Prepared by	Ecology Consulting — WHS / Field team	Document release date	
Approved by	Tony Webster — Managing Director / WHS Officer	Next review	

Note: Work must be performed in accordance with this Safe Work Method Statement (SWMS). This SWMS must be kept and available for inspection until the work is completed. If revised, every version must be kept. If a notifiable incident occurs in relation to the work in this SWMS, the SWMS must be kept for at least two years from the date of the notifiable incident. This SWMS is accessed and acknowledged through the Ecology Consulting digital WHS platform; field forms are submitted from site and reviewed centrally by the administration team.

Scope & limitations: Works are limited to ecological survey and observation only. **Ecology Consulting personnel will not undertake electrical work and will not interfere with electrical infrastructure, plant or controls.** Work will not proceed where safe approach distances cannot be maintained. All work near electrical assets must comply with the relevant Network Operator requirements (for example Essential Energy or Ausgrid) and Safe Approach Distances. **Where voltage is unknown, the highest applicable exclusion distance shall be applied.** Under no circumstances are Ecology Consulting personnel permitted to enter electrical No-Go Zones.

Project & PCBU details

Person conducting a business or undertaking (PCBU)	Ecology Consulting Pty Ltd · ABN 68 647 633 163	Contact number	0472 569 988 (office / Check-in)
EC offices	34 Atchison St, Wollongong NSW 2500 · 42 Goulburn St, Crookwell NSW 2583 · 473 Townsend St, Albury NSW 2640		
Client / Principal Contractor			
Work activity	Ecological survey, pre-clearing survey, habitat inspection, clearing supervision and fauna rescue on or near energised overhead and underground electrical installations and services.		
Workplace location			

Field work duration	
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Legislation, codes of practice & standards

Acts & Regulations	Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (NSW) and the Work Health and Safety Regulation (NSW); Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (Cth) and WHS Regulations 2011 (Cth) where work is on Commonwealth land or for a Commonwealth entity (Comcare jurisdiction); Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (ACT) and WHS Regulation 2011 (ACT) for works in the ACT.
Codes of Practice	Safe Work Australia model Codes as adopted in NSW and the ACT: <i>How to manage work health and safety risks; Work health and safety consultation, cooperation and coordination; Construction work; First aid in the workplace; Managing the work environment and facilities; Preparation of safe work method statements for construction work. Managing electrical risks in the workplace; Managing risks of plant in the workplace; Traffic management in workplaces.</i>
Standards & guidance	Network Operator Safe Approach Distances and No-Go Zone requirements (Essential Energy, Ausgrid or relevant DNSP); AS/NZS 4602 High visibility safety garments; AS/NZS 1801 Occupational protective helmets; AS 1319 Safety signs. Before You Dig Australia (BYDA) service location.
EC WHS documentation	EC Work Health and Safety Management System and WHS Handbook; EC Risk Management Processes (EC-RMP-FRM-001); EC Hazard Register and Trigger Action Response List (TARL); Pre-Mobilisation Checklist; Pre-Travel Vehicle Safety Checklist; Journey Management Plan; Daily Toolbox Talk; site-specific Emergency Response Plan (ERP); JSA — General Field Surveys; JSA — Remote and Isolated Work; SOP — Journey Management; SOP — Terrestrial Fauna; SOP — Fieldwork Biosecurity. SWMS16 — Work in an area with movement of powered mobile plant; SWMS15 — Work on, in or adjacent to a traffic corridor; SOP — Clearing Supervision; JSA — Preclearing; JSA — Clearing Supervision.

Mandatory personal protective equipment & field equipment

Confirmed present and serviceable on the Pre-Mobilisation Checklist and verified by the Field Lead at the Daily Toolbox Talk. Faulty items are tagged out and removed from service.

Hard Hat	Safety Glasses	Gloves	Hearing Protection	Hi-Vis Clothing	Sun Safe PPE	Wide Brim Hat	Capped Boots
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Fire Extinguisher	Remote First Aid Kit	Snake Bite Kit	In Reach / Sat Phone	Two-Way Radio	Torch / Headlamp	GPS	Drinking Water
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Non-Conductive PPE	BYDA Plans	Exclusion Zone Delineation	Two-Way Radio	Binoculars (remote observation)	Lightning Tracker	Site Induction Card	Dust Mask
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Hierarchy of controls

Eliminate	Avoid working near energised electrical assets wherever practicable by redesigning survey methods — conduct assessments from safe distances and use remote observation tools such as binoculars, cameras or drones.
Substitute	Use safer work methods that minimise proximity to electrical hazards — undertake surveys from ground locations outside exclusion zones, or use existing data instead of field verification near live assets.
Isolate	Establish and maintain electrical exclusion zones and No-Go Zones in accordance with Network Operator requirements; physically separate personnel, equipment and vehicles from energised assets.
Engineer	Use engineered controls implemented by the Principal Contractor such as barriers, bollards, insulated covers where applicable, defined access routes, and physical separation from electrical infrastructure.
Administrative	SWMS, site inductions, permits where required, verification of asset locations including BYDA, confirmation of Safe Approach Distances, communication protocols, supervision and strict stop-work triggers; enforce no entry into exclusion zones under any circumstances.
PPE	Last line of defence only — non-conductive PPE where applicable, helmets, safety boots, gloves and high visibility clothing. PPE must not be relied upon as the primary control for electrical risk.

Hazards & controls

Complete daily. Safe approach distances must be confirmed before work commences.

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Planning, preparation and travelling to site		
Inadequate planning leading to uncontrolled risk; unfit or untrained personnel	Attend the pre-field meeting with the Project Lead and Project Manager to review scope, methodology and expected hazards; confirm site access, keys, codes, inductions and property constraints; and confirm all staff are trained, competent and fit for work. Medical concerns are disclosed privately to the Field Lead. Review this SWMS, the relevant JSA and SOP, the Field Plan and the site-specific ERP. Verify training currency — workers are not mobilised with expired mandatory training.	☐ Pre-field meeting ☐ SWMS / JSA / SOP reviewed ☐ ERP reviewed ☐ Training verified ☐ Medical disclosures
Vehicle failure, missing safety equipment or fatigue during travel	Complete the Pre-Travel Vehicle Safety Checklist — first aid kit, extinguisher, spare tyre, torch, water and PPE present; vehicle free from leaks, faults or damage; electrical issues visually inspected only and tagged out if unsafe. Complete the Journey Management Plan. Minimum 10-hour rest between shifts before driving; personal fatigue self-assessment before departure; rest breaks every two hours; carry water, snacks and electrolytes; second driver for long or remote trips where practicable. Zero blood alcohol concentration applies to all work driving.	☐ Vehicle checklist done ☐ JMP completed ☐ 10-hr rest confirmed ☐ Fatigue self-assessment
Travelling into fire, flood, storm, smoke or hazardous road conditions	Complete the Pre-Travel Environmental and Hazard Check using BOM weather warnings, Hazards Near Me, RFS fire danger ratings, Air Quality Index, lightning trackers, Live Traffic NSW and telecommunications coverage maps. Do not travel where there are emergency warning fire events, hazardous air quality, active storm warnings or flooded roads. Never drive through floodwater under any circumstance. If conditions change, stop, reassess and notify the Communication Officer.	☐ BOM / Hazards Near Me ☐ RFS rating checked ☐ AQI checked ☐ Live Traffic NSW ☐ Coverage checked
Hazards not identified, assessed or communicated before work commences	All team members participate in a pre-commencement Daily Toolbox Talk led on site by the Field Lead and documented on the EC WHS form — site-specific hazards identified; collaborative risk assessment using the EC risk matrix (rating one to six) with agreed controls and a revised residual rating; PPE and equipment readiness confirmed; ERP reviewed and Emergency Meeting Point identified; communication and check-in requirements confirmed; health or access needs disclosed privately; and worker sign-on confirming understanding and fitness for work. Hazards already in the EC Hazard Register are managed under the TARL. No worker commences without sign-on.	☐ Toolbox talk held ☐ Risk assessment rated ☐ Emergency Meeting Point ☐ All workers signed on
Loss of contact with the field team; delayed emergency response	Mandatory check-ins with the Communication Officer (0472 569 988) before departing base, on arrival at site or accommodation, before leaving site, and on return to base. Every check-in must be acknowledged. A missed or unacknowledged check-in triggers escalation through the Communication Officer, Project Lead or Project Manager, and the WHS Officer, and is grounds for activating the ERP. Carry redundant communications — mobile phone, UHF radio and In Reach or satellite communicator, with a PLB where remoteness warrants. Roles are assigned at the toolbox talk: Field Lead, Communication Officer and workers.	☐ Check-in schedule agreed ☐ Comms tested ☐ Roles assigned ☐ Escalation briefed
Scope, induction and approach distances		

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Misinterpretation of role leading to unsafe interaction with electrical infrastructure; unauthorised work near energised assets	Works are limited to ecological survey and observation only. Ecology Consulting personnel will not undertake electrical work and will not interfere with electrical infrastructure, plant or controls. Work will not proceed where safe approach distances cannot be maintained. The scope limitation is briefed and acknowledged at the toolbox talk.	☐ Scope understood ☐ Work within limits ☐ Acknowledged at toolbox
Lack of awareness of electrical hazards; incorrect assumptions about safe distances	All personnel must complete a site-specific induction prior to commencing work. The induction must include electrical hazard awareness, and exclusion zones and approach distances. Only authorised personnel are permitted to work near electrical assets.	☐ Induction completed ☐ Hazards briefed ☐ Authorisation confirmed
Encroachment into unsafe distance from energised assets; misjudgement of voltage or clearance requirements	All work must comply with Network Operator requirements and Safe Approach Distances. Under no circumstances are personnel permitted to enter electrical No-Go Zones. Where voltage is unknown, the highest applicable exclusion distance must be applied. Maintain safe distance from all electrical assets at all times, and confirm distances with the Principal Contractor before commencing.	☐ Distance verified ☐ Voltage known or assumed ☐ No-Go Zones confirmed
Toolbox talk and establishing work areas		
Miscommunication of electrical hazards; unclear roles; failure to identify exclusion zones; delayed emergency response	Conduct a formal daily pre-start briefing clearly identifying electrical assets (overhead and underground), exclusion zones and approach distances, and no-go areas and plant interaction risks. Confirm roles, responsibilities and communication protocols. Review emergency procedures and stop-work triggers. Ensure all personnel understand and acknowledge the SWMS and JSA. The Supervisor verifies all controls are in place prior to work.	☐ Toolbox / induction completed ☐ Roles assigned ☐ SWMS signed ☐ Controls verified
Encroachment into approach distances; contact with live conductors, direct or indirect; public or workers entering unsafe areas; induced voltage from nearby assets	The Principal Contractor establishes exclusion zones in accordance with network authority requirements. Identify and mark all overhead and underground services — BYDA plans are mandatory. Install signage, barriers, bunting and physical controls. Maintain minimum approach distances at all times. Do not store materials or park vehicles under powerlines. Use a spotter where working near exclusion boundaries. Stop work if line movement caused by wind creates increased risk.	☐ Exclusion zones in place ☐ BYDA reviewed ☐ Spotter assigned ☐ Nothing stored under lines
Contact with underground electrical services; striking live cables	Obtain current BYDA plans prior to work and supplement them with physical identification onsite using markers, pits and visual indicators. Treat all unverified or unidentified services as live. No ground disturbance within service corridors. Ecology Consulting personnel do not excavate.	☐ BYDA reviewed ☐ Services verified onsite ☐ No ground disturbance
Survey activities near electrical assets		
Equipment contacting overhead electrical lines; raising equipment into exclusion zones	Maintain separation distance when using GPS poles, cameras, tripods and vehicles. Do not lift, carry or position equipment near conductors. Keep all equipment below safe height limits and carry long items horizontally, not vertically, when moving beneath lines.	☐ Equipment controlled ☐ Below height limits ☐ Carried horizontally
Unidentified electrical hazards; workers unknowingly entering unsafe areas	Verify all warning signage and exclusion markers are in place. Ensure signage is visible, clear and understood. Do not enter areas without confirmed hazard identification.	☐ Signage verified ☐ Markers in place

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Vegetation in contact with live electrical assets; slips, trips and falls; fauna interaction and zoonotic exposure; limited visibility	Confirm service locations via BYDA and site inspection. Maintain exclusion distances from overhead and underground assets. Do not inspect or approach vegetation contacting powerlines — report it to the Principal Contractor and the Network Operator. Use remote observation methods such as binoculars or GPS where risk exists. Wear mandatory PPE. Apply hygiene controls for zoonotic risk. Stop work if visibility is reduced. Habitat inspections are conducted only by trained ecologists, in daylight or adequate lighting only.	☐ Services identified ☐ Vegetation not approached ☐ Remote observation used ☐ PPE compliant
Slips, trips and falls; distraction while using devices; environmental exposure during data collection and site movement	Maintain situational awareness at all times. Stop moving when recording data — do not walk while using devices. Maintain separation from electrical infrastructure. Use safe access routes only. Avoid unstable or waterlogged areas. Apply PPE and hydration controls.	☐ Safe movement maintained ☐ Stop to record ☐ Safe routes only
Clearing supervision and fauna rescue		
Plant operating near live electrical infrastructure; falling trees or limbs contacting conductors; arc flash or flashover; communication breakdown around machinery	Ecology Consulting staff are engaged to supervise the clearing process only and are observers — they do not direct plant unless authorised. Maintain safe observation distance outside exclusion zones. Confirm electrical no-go zones prior to work. Under no circumstances are Ecology personnel permitted to enter electrical No-Go Zones. Ensure plant operators and arborists comply with approach distance requirements. Maintain continuous communication with plant operators and spotters. Stop work immediately if plant breaches an exclusion zone. Cease work during high winds or poor visibility. Refer to SWMS16 for further mobile plant controls.	☐ Observer role maintained ☐ Observation position safe ☐ No-go zones confirmed ☐ SWMS16 applied
Bites, scratches and envenomation during fauna rescue; zoonotic disease exposure; proximity to electrical hazards; plant restart or movement	Only trained and authorised personnel handle fauna. Ensure all plant is stopped and isolated before rescue. Do not conduct rescue near live conductors or within exclusion zones. Use appropriate PPE including gloves and respiratory protection where required. Ground-based rescue only — no climbing or elevated work. Avoid direct contact with animal droppings, carcasses or urine-soaked material. Do not handle bats unless vaccinated and authorised. Wash or sanitise hands before breaks and after fauna handling. Report any sick or unusual wildlife to the Supervisor. Confirm all-clear before works resume.	☐ Plant stopped ☐ Rescue authorised ☐ Outside exclusion zone ☐ Ground-based only ☐ Hand hygiene
Weather and ground conditions		
Lightning strike, increased near infrastructure; wind causing conductor movement or tree failure; heat stress; reduced visibility	Continuously monitor weather and lightning conditions. Stop work if lightning is detected within 10 km and shelter in a hard-topped vehicle. Cease work in high winds affecting stability or conductor movement. Implement hydration and heat management controls. Stop work if visibility is impaired.	☐ Weather monitored ☐ Lightning within 10 km rule ☐ Stop triggers understood
Wet conditions increasing conductivity and arc or flashover risk; slips and unstable ground	Do not work near electrical assets during unsafe wet conditions. Maintain stable footing and avoid slick surfaces. Delay or cease works during heavy rain. Reassess conditions prior to recommencing. Cease work where moisture, humidity or dust increases electrical risk, and maintain increased separation distances where environmental conditions change.	☐ Conditions reassessed ☐ Increased separation ☐ Work delayed if wet

Stop-work triggers — stop work immediately, move to a safe location, notify the Field Lead and Principal Contractor, and do not recommence until the risk is controlled and communicated			
Breach or risk of breach of an exclusion distance	Uncertainty about asset voltage or location	Missing or unclear exclusion zones	Equipment at risk of breaching approach distance
Unsafe plant interaction	Unknown underground or overhead service identified	Loss of communication	Lightning within 10 km, high wind or wet conditions

Emergency response

Read with the site-specific Emergency Response Plan. The Field Lead is the Chief Warden. Any worker may activate the ERP.

1 · Activate & make safe	Stop work and ensure the area is safe for responders. Do not move an injured person unless there is immediate danger. For electrical contact, do not approach or touch the casualty or any plant, vehicle or vegetation in contact with a conductor . Keep all persons at least eight metres clear and shuffle away with small steps to avoid step potential. Call 000 and the Network Operator immediately (Essential Energy general enquiries 13 23 56) and request isolation. Do not commence first aid until the Network Operator or emergency services confirm the asset is isolated and safe. The Field Lead assesses the situation, initiates the response, directs evacuation to the Emergency Meeting Point, accounts for all personnel using the Daily Toolbox Talk sign-on sheet, and coordinates communication with the office.
2 · Call for help	Call 000 or 112, or activate the In Reach or PLB where there is no coverage. Provide GPS coordinates and the nearest cross roads, the nature of the emergency and safe access routes. Assign one person to guide responders in.
3 · First aid	A trained first aider assesses the casualty, but only where it is safe to do so. Control bleeding, immobilise suspected fractures and monitor breathing. If unconscious but breathing, place in the recovery position; if not breathing, commence CPR. Record all treatment on the First Aid Treatment Log.
4 · Post-incident	Report to the WHS Officer and complete an Incident Report Form within the required timeframe, submitted through the digital WHS platform. The WHS Officer updates the Incident Register and notifies the regulator of any notifiable incident. Attend debrief; review and update this SWMS and the ERP; restock emergency equipment used. Psychosocial support is provided where workers were exposed to distressing events.

Emergency services	000 or 112	State Emergency Service (SES)	13 25 00
EC office / Check-in Officer	0472 569 988	Managing Director / WHS Officer	Tony Webster · 0448 439 334
Poisons Information Hotline	13 11 26	Wildlife rescue	1300 094 737
Employee Assistance Program	1300 172 327 — free and confidential	Nearest hospital & muster point	Identified per site in the ERP; confirmed at the toolbox talk

Training & competency requirements

Required for this activity	White Card (General Construction Induction) is mandatory. A site-specific electrical induction including hazard awareness, exclusion zones and approach distances is mandatory before commencing. Spotter Certification is required where a worker acts as an electrical safety observer. Fauna Handling Training and snake handling awareness or accreditation are required for fauna interaction activities.
Baseline — all field personnel	White Card (General Construction Induction); current driver's licence of appropriate class; CPR certification (annual renewal); Provide First Aid (HLTAID011), and Remote First Aid (HLTAID013) for remote or isolated work; General Fauna Handling Training.
Verification	All training must be current, recorded and verifiable prior to mobilisation. Records are maintained by the Administration Officer and retained for a minimum of five years, with expiry notifications issued in advance; workers are not mobilised with expired mandatory training. Competency is verified annually and observed on site by Principal or Senior Ecologists, Project Managers and the WHS Officer. Subcontractor training evidence is collected and retained for audit.

Daily SWMS acknowledgement & sign-on register

All personnel must read, understand and sign this SWMS before commencing work, confirming they are fit for duty, competent and able to perform assigned tasks safely. Completed with the Daily Toolbox Talk and submitted through the digital WHS platform.

#	Name	Role	Signature	Date
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				

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